How to find a postdoc

CIDI T32 Meeting
Tuesday, November 18, 2025

Jesus E. Vazquez and Diana Alvarez Bartolo

JOHNS HOPKINS
UNIVERSITY

Who we are?



Jesus E. Vazquez

- PhD in Biostatistics from the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill (2025)
- **Favorite movies:** White Chicks, Kpop Demon Hunters, both Avatar Movies.



Diana Alvarez Bartolo

- PhD in Quantitative Research Methods from Arizona State University (2025)
- **Favorite movies:** Amelie, Parasite, Memoirs of a snail.

Is a postdoc for me?

Transitional position from PhD to other positions (e.g., assistant professor).

Reasons to do a postdoc?

- Learn new skills or/and research.
- Gain more independence.
- Expand network (collaborations, societies).
- Strengthen CV for future academic (and industry) position applications.
  - More papers
  - Explore teaching pedagogies
  - Improve mentorship styles

Reasons not to do a postdoc?

- You are 100% sure on what you want to do (long-term) after your PhD, *and you have a strong application.*
- Industry (non-research) outlook.
- Other potential reasons include:
  - Family
  - Financial
  - Relocation (temporary position)

What to look for in a postdoc?

Research alignment

- Either in same direction or different (learn about other areas).

Mentorship style

- Philosophy and availability.

Location and length of program

- Geography and cost of living.
- How long will I stay here?

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- How long will I stay here?

Funding type

- Private Funding
  - JHU Provost's Postdoctoral Fellowship
  - Harvard University Yerby Fellowship
  - Brown University Presidential Fellowship
- Public funding
  - T32 Programs
- Industry (e.g., pharmaceutical)
  - Collaborations with academic institutions.

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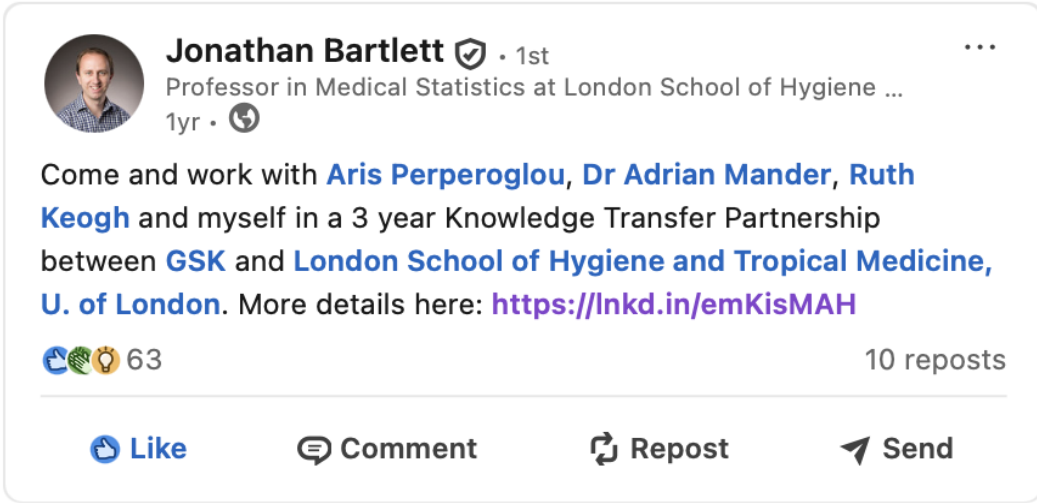
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How to look for a postdoc?

Field related pages

- Biostatistics/Statistics
  - University of Florida – Statistics
- Prevention research
  - Society for Prevention Research
- Mental/Psychology Health Research
  - Psychology Jobs Wiki
  - Association for Psychological Science
- LinkedIn + Social Media

Mentors + Colleagues

- Ask your PhD advisor (committee) + classmates.

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Conferences

- Networking opportunities during research talks + social hours.

Reach out directly

- Email PIs to ask about potential postdoc opportunities.

Field specific mail-lists

- Quantitative psychology (Amanda Montoya, UCLA).
- Find people in your field!

Science Article (link)

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2. Diversity statement

Resources

- JHU Doctoral life design studio
- Harvard University Template
- UPenn Career Services
- Overleaf Templates

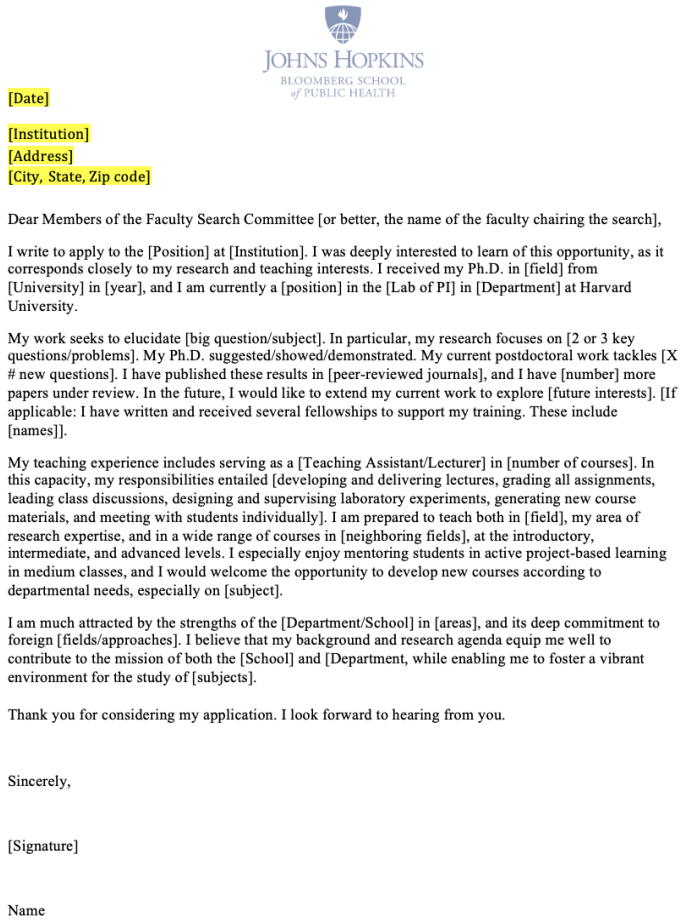
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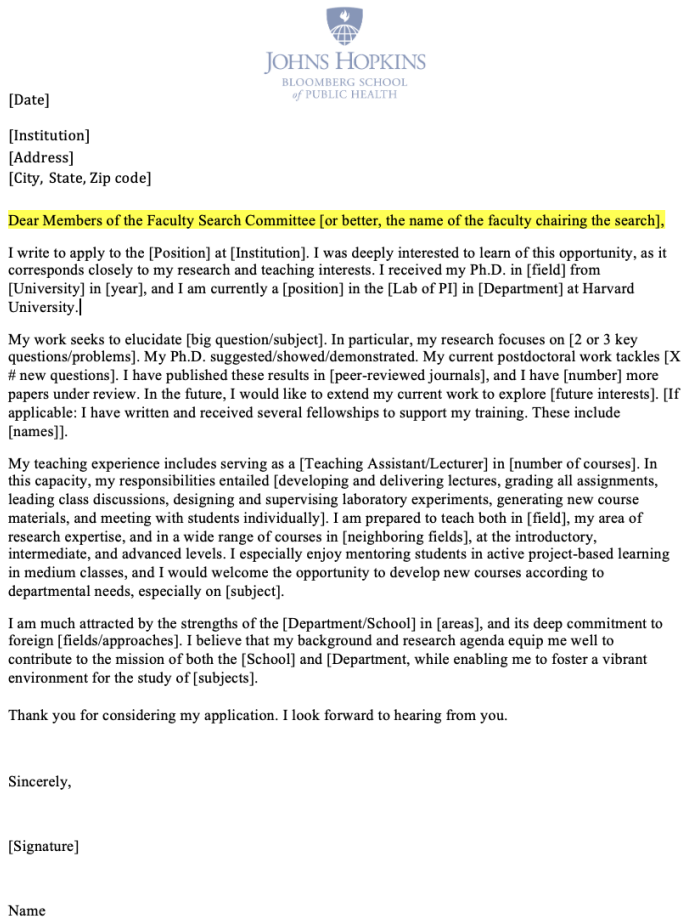
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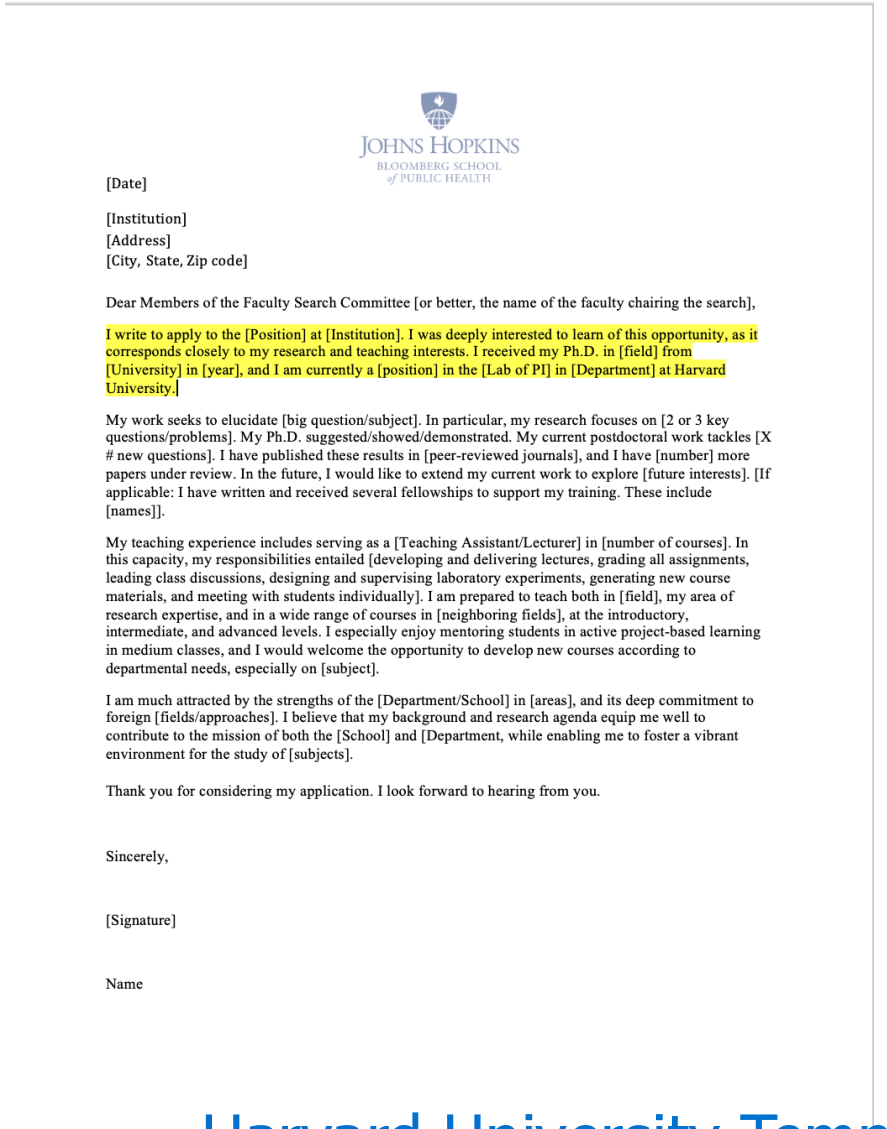
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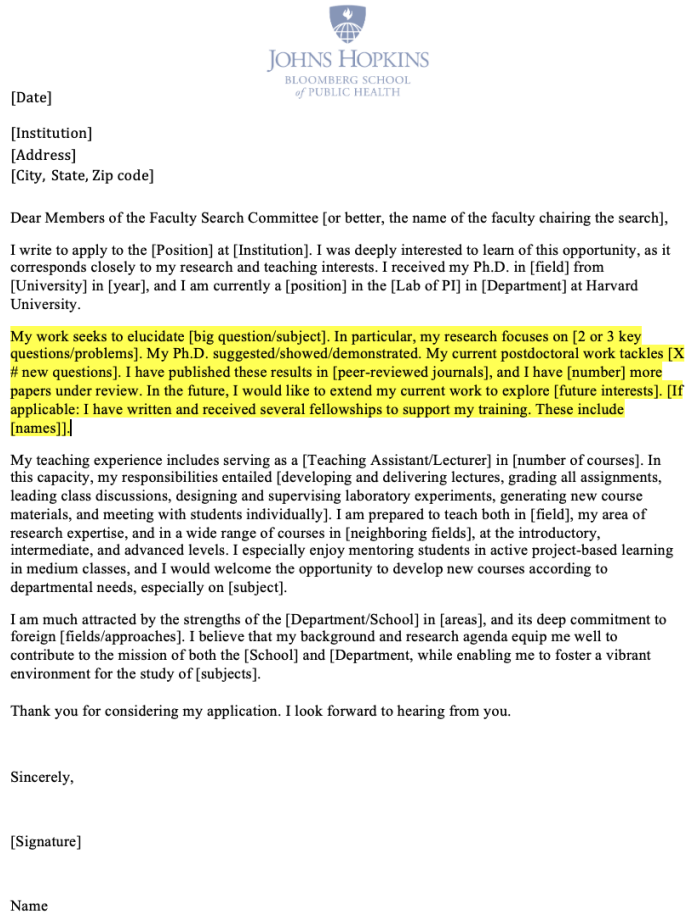
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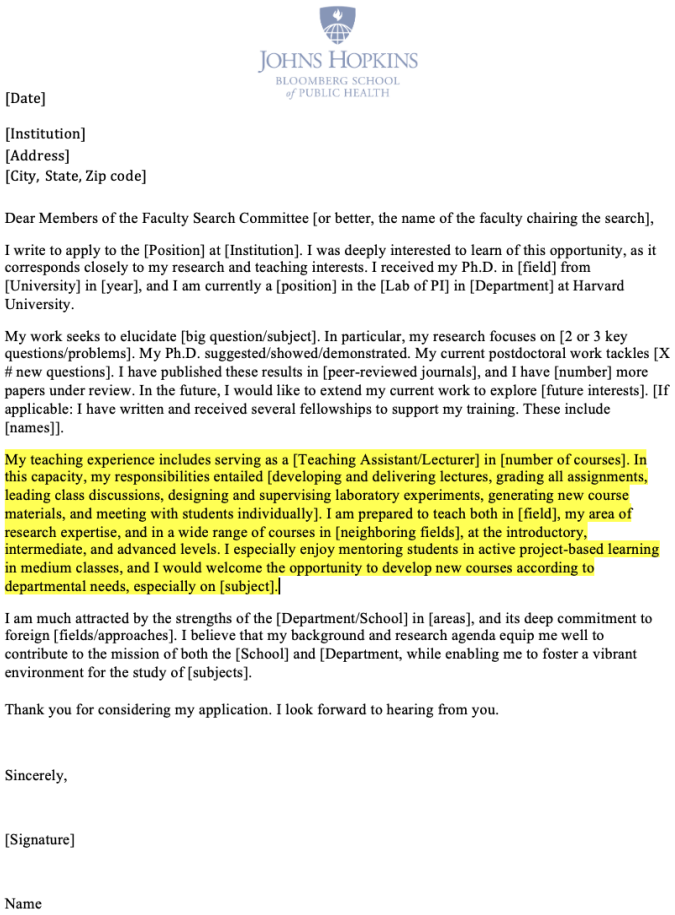
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Asking for one:

- Make sure you give your references enough time (min 1 month; talk to them)
- References may ask you to first write one for yourself.
- Clear instruction and share application materials in a timely manner.

Submission cases:

- Interfolio
- Sent directly to program/PI

Potential Scenarios:

- May or may not talk to references.
- May need them once you make it into the "short list."

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What can you submit?

- Peer-reviewed publications
- Preprints
- Manuscript draft

What should I send?

- Prioritize first-author papers.
- Pick them based on relevance to job and project description.

Interview

The basics

- Dress appropriately and turn-off phone.
- If Zoom, pick a quiet place that has reliable internet. Also, good lighting and stable camera.
- Have presentation ready to go (including elevator speech).
- STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result) examples.
- "Do you have any questions" — Yes!

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Before the presentation

1. Relax (try some exercises)
2. Warm up vocal cords (Youtube)
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During presentation

- Enunciate
- Be careful on monotonic tone.
- Stay present (make eye contact if in person; take *understanding*-breaks if on Zoom)

After presentation

- Ask follow-up questions.
- Be prepared and honest if you not know the answer to questions – however, make a note to show interest and [potentially] follow up.

An exercise for better pronunciation

Step 1: Pick one sentence and say it 3 times.

- How much wood would a woodchuck chuck if a woodchuck could chuck wood?
- She sells seashells by the seashore.

Step 2: Repeat Step 1, while biting your tongue

Step 3: Repeat Step 1, normally

Other thoughts

Do your research

- Chat with current postdocs + students of lab group or PI.

Timing of offers

- Generally, make decisions 2-weeks post offer.
- Be honest and transparent about needing more time to decide.
- Do your research

Read your offer letter

- Ask questions about requirements (teaching, mentorship, or pure research focused).
- Vacation and benefits.
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Multiple offers

- Politely reach out to leverage potential additional benefits.

Declining offers

- Don't make enemies – try to soften the punch.
- Political approach – may be chairs of hiring committees for a future position you apply for.

Short activity

Q1: What is one question I will ask every potential mentor?

Q2: What are career outcomes that I want my postdoc to prepare me for?

Q3: What are skills and experiences that I want to get out from a potential postdoc?

Q4: Why do you want to do a postdoc?

Thank You!

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Diana Alvarez Bartolo, PhD
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